

REVIEW OF WELSH GOVERNMENT COMMUNICATIONS WITH MISTER PETER MANDELSON

Remit

The Leader of Plaid Cymru wrote to the First Minister on 5 February asking her to investigate any dealings that the Welsh Government may have had with Peter Mandelson in his official government roles. In her response the First Minister said that she had asked the Permanent Secretary to look into the issues raised in the letter in order to understand the nature of any Welsh Government dealings with Peter Mandelson, and whether there was any risk to the conduct of Welsh Government business during the periods of Peter Mandelson's official UK Government roles.

Actions

In response to the request from the First Minister we have:

- Searched our electronic files and paper records for relevant material at the times when Mr Mandelson held public office
- Searched the Epstein files for relevant materials
- Reviewed the contacts which our US offices had with Mr Mandelson at the time he was US Ambassador
- Considered whether the Welsh Government ever had any dealings with Global Counsel.

Review of Records

We have sought to identify the records held by the Welsh Government which might have contained correspondence or references to Mr Mandelson at the time he held government office. This goes back to 2008 originally, when the Welsh Government was still using paper records, which are harder to search. In addition, some records which might have held relevant information had already been destroyed in accordance with our normal procedures

The initial searches identified over 2,500 individual electronic records or paper files which might potentially have reference to Mr Mandelson or correspondence with him in his official roles. Removing duplications and ephemera narrowed this down to around 1,000 items and these electronic files and paper records were individually inspected.

This inspection found 48 documents which included correspondence with Mr Mandelson or references to him in internal correspondence. These items are listed and summarised in the annex to this report.

We shared the relevant documents with our colleagues in our Economic Policy and Strategy Department. They spoke to individuals who were involved in trade and investment activity at the times that Peter Mandelson was in office as Business Secretary. They spoke to Welsh Government colleagues in the US who were working in the Embassy at the time that he was the UK's Ambassador to the USA. They also undertook a separate trawl of iShare files to see if they could find anything relevant. Their view was that neither the iShare trawl nor conversations with Wales-based colleagues identified any documents that demonstrate a risk to WG business during these periods, or any direct links to Mr. Mandelson.

Search of Epstein Files

We have searched the US Department of Justice "Epstein Library" using search terms in relation to the Welsh Government and the Senedd. The only item found was an ephemeral exchange of messages on 23 July 2009 when Mr Mandelson said *"Travelling back to London from Cardiff. Urgent ? Or call u on return."* and Mr Epstein responded *"call me when you get a chance."* The occasion was a visit to Cardiff by Mr Mandelson in his role as Business Secretary. Mr Mandelson attended a meeting of the UK Cabinet held in Cardiff where an announcement was made by the then Prime Minister of the electrification of the railway line between London and Cardiff.

The Epstein Library was also interrogated using the following search terms, which came up during the inspection of our records: Anglesey Aluminium; Corus; Airbus Broughton; GXS Limited; and People's Bank. The only finding was several documents about Corus, but these were of a general information nature and did not make any reference to Wales in particular, nor appeared to have any links to Mr. Mandelson.

Contact with Mr Mandelson when he was US Ambassador

In the USA, Welsh Government officials are based in the British Embassy and work side by side with UK Government officials and the Ambassador, as well as in Consulates across the country. Discussions with the team there have identified the following contact points during Mr Mandelson's tenure:

- FM meeting (22 January 2025) - This was the introductory meeting between the FM and the Ambassador (via Teams). No written information about the Welsh Government's relationship and priorities was shared with the UK Government or Peter Mandelson.
- Minister for Culture, Skills and Social Partnership 'brush by' while at Games Developers Conference (March 2025) – A meeting between MCSSP and the Ambassador was requested but the Embassy declined, citing his schedule. The Embassy offered a 'brush by' at a Department for Business and Trade reception that both were attending. Our official in Los Angeles cannot recall if the brush by actually happened it is very unlikely that any exchange of substance took place even if they did.

- The Ambassador very occasionally chaired the weekly Monday Morning Meeting for senior members of Embassy staff, including the leads for the Devolved Governments, however these were frequently passed to the Deputy Ambassador to chair on his behalf. No direct interactions occurred at these meetings with the Ambassador, and no documents were sent (or contributed to) in support of these meetings.

Dealings with Global Counsel

We have found no record of the Welsh Government making any payments to Global Counsel or having any contacts with the company.

Conclusion

The First Minister needs to be aware that we cannot guarantee that we have found every communication with Mr Mandelson which might exist, or did exist, on Welsh Government records. Some of our earliest records have been destroyed and it may be the case that other relevant material is held on files which have not been thrown up by our search terms.

Subject to the caveat, however, the work which we have completed has found only a very limited number of relevant items or occasions where Mr Mandelson was mentioned or was the subject of correspondence or meetings. The items which we have found are either not significant or reflect the normal course of business, and are unexceptional. We have not found anything which in our view represented a risk to the conduct of Welsh Government business during the periods of Peter Mandelson's official UK Government roles.

Propriety and Ethics Team

March 2026

Welsh Government

Mandelson Review - Summary/Numbers of documents found and reviewed

Documents found via Records management	
Initial Search Results from Records Management team	Number of docs
iShare Digital Records	170 digital documents
iShare Paper Records	605 paper files
Digital FM Mailboxes	1,985 emails and attachments
The final number of search results after removal of Ephemera from Records Management team	Number of docs
iShare Digital Records	239 digital documents
iShare Paper Records	32 paper files
Digital FM Mailboxes	686 emails and attachments

Documents Reviewed after identification through key themes	
Nuix (FM mailbox) - Digital documents 1 st review	65
Nuix (FM mailbox) - Digital documents 2 nd review	24
iShare Digital documents reviewed 1 st review	44
iShare Digital documents - Further 2 nd review	20
iShare Paper files - 1st Tranche	32 files (4 docs scanned for 2nd review)
iShare Paper files - 2nd Tranche	18 files (none identified for 2nd review)

Document type	Doc Number	Description	Date of Doc	Summary of item
Nuix	N116	DFM-00829-09 - Ld Mandelson re NINJ - 20-04-09 - draft reply.doc	20 May 2009	Draft letter from DFM, Ieuan Wyn Jones, to PM following a letter from PM (Doc N117) providing a copy of " <i>New Industry, New Jobs</i> " statement.
Nuix	N117	DFM-00829-09 - The Rt Hon Lord Mandelson - 20-05-09 - letter-173056.pdf	20 April 2009	Letter to FM from PM re " <i>New Industry, New Jobs</i> " statement.
Nuix	N118	DFM-02034-08 - The Rt Hon Lord Mandelson - 07-11-08 - reply-131115.pdf	26 November 2008	Letter from DFM, Ieuan Wyn Jones, to PM regarding " <i>Solutions for Business</i> " and the Welsh Government's " <i>Flexible Support for Business</i> " scheme.
Nuix	N252	FW: Emailing: 2008.12.04 - PDS Letter p1.JPG, 2008.12.04 - PDS Letter p2.JPG	4 December 2008	Email from business owner to FM who has included a copy of a letter they have sent to PM for business help.
Nuix	N262a	FW: IMMEDIATE/RESTRICTED. Mandelson's Low Carbon Industrial Strategy	6 July 2009	Exchanges following receipt of Lord Mandelson's Low Carbon Industrial Strategy.
Nuix	N262b	FW: IMMEDIATE/RESTRICTED. Mandelson's	9 July 2009	Exchanges following receipt of Lord Mandelson's Low Carbon

		Low Carbon Industrial Strategy		Industrial Strategy.
Nuix	N281	FW: RESTRICTED - UK CABINET MINISTERS' VISITS	16 July 2009	Exchanges regarding visit by Lord Mandelson and other UK cabinet members to Wales.
Nuix	N294	FW: URGENT - NUMBER 10 BRIEFING - Anglesey Aluminium	1 July 2009	Information requested for Number 10 briefing from Wales Office regarding Anglesey Aluminium.
Nuix	N303	HIGHLY CONFIDENTIAL AND IMMEDIATE: Anglesey Aluminium	24 October 2008	Lines to FM from policy team regarding Anglesey Aluminium. Lines suggest discussion with PM.
Nuix	N309	Letter to Lord Mandelson	4 March 2009	Draft letter to PM regarding Royal Mail following publication of "Hooper Report". Draft version found but no final version can be identified.
Nuix	N343	MBDFM0075/09 - Meeting with Corus - 11-02-09.	5 February 2009	Briefing for DFM, Ieuan Wyn Jones, for meeting with Managing Director of Corus. Briefing includes reference to PM.
Nuix	N366	MB-FM-0393-09 - AAM, Job Losses.doc	14 July 2009	Advice to FM following confirmation that Anglesey Aluminium were intending to make 300 compulsory redundancies the following day. Reference in briefing to a conversation between Chair of the Rio Tinto Board (Anglesey Aluminium Metal) and

				PM.
Nuix	N459	Peter Mandelson to David Miliband pb1609.pdf	16 September 2009	Copy of letter from PM to David Milliband regarding European Micro Credit Activity.
Nuix	N583	RE: RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	8 June 2009	Exchanges regarding Airbus announcement at Paris Airshow with reference made to PM.
Nuix	N584	RE: RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	8 June 2009	Confirmation of FM availability for Airbus announcement at Paris Airshow. Same reference to PM as Doc N583.
Nuix	N585	RE: RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	24 March 2009	Feedback on conversation between FM and PM regarding Airbus and implications of DBERR departing from agreed approach.
Nuix	N586	Re: RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	5 June 2009	Comms response to exchanges at Doc N583. (with reference made to PM)
Nuix	N587	RE: RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	8 June 2009	Policy response to Doc N584 (with reference made to PM).
Nuix	N605	RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	23 March 2009	Policy updates regarding conversation with DBERR officials regarding Airbus prior to FM's telephone conversation with PM (as noted at Doc N585).
Nuix	N606	RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	26 March 2009	2 nd Draft letter and advice from officials for the FM to send to PM following their conversation noted at Doc N585. First draft

				detailed in Doc N607
Nuix	N607	RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	25 March 2009	Initial draft letter and advice from FM to PM following conversation at Doc N585. Second draft prepared at Doc N606.
Nuix	N608	RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	27 March 2009	Policy updates regarding conversation with DBERR officials regarding Airbus and seeking a letter from PM.
Nuix	N609	RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	2 April 2009	Policy updates on a letter of comfort from PM re Airbus prior to Welsh Industrial Development Advisory Board (WIDAB) recommendation.
Nuix	N610	RESTRICTED - COMMERCIAL - AIRBUS	21 May 2009	Initial Ministerial indication from officials for announcement at Paris airshow regarding Airbus. References DBERR.
Paper	P1	AD/00968/06: Airbus, Broughton - Janet Ryder AM Correspondence	13 June 2006	Advise and response to Janet Ryder AM who was seeking information on job security at Airbus and seeking further information on the launch of contracts and the EADS undertakings. Draft response included. No direct reference to PM.
Paper	P2	DFM/00147/09 - Letter DFM, Ieuan Wyn Jones, to John Griffiths AM	6 April 2009	Letter to John Griffiths from Ieuan Wyn Jones. References a company GXS Limited who pitched

				a factoring service to PM.
Paper	P3	DFM/0204/08 – Government Solutions for Business	27 October 2008	Correspondence on the UK Government 'Solutions for Business' in England from DBERR – Rt Hon Lord Mandelson. WG response wasn't on file
Paper	P4	MB/DFM/00285/09 – GMAC UK PLC visit 26 March 2009	26 March 2009	Briefing for visit to discuss assistance for the company following Lord Mandelson's announcement on 27 January 2009 of a support package for the automotive manufacturing sector.
iShare	I1	05/09 COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 23.3.09	23 March 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. Ref PM page 10 point 5 re Airbus. Ref Secretary of State re Anglesey Aluminium page 13 point 14.
iShare	I2	06/09 COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 6.4.09	6 April 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 17 point 5 re Airbus.

iShare	I3	08/09 COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 5.5.09	5 May 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 6 point 15. Ref to PM page 2 point 6 re Airbus.
iShare	I4	09/09 COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 18.5.09	18 May 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 6 point 6 re Airbus. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 10 point 15.
iShare	I7	090330-mc to dh-RE: Airbus	30 March 2009	Official exchanges to update Counsel General on current legal issues. Duplicate info to docs i1-i4 above.
iShare	I10	10/09 COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 1.6.09	1 June 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 3 point 6 re Airbus. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 6 point 15.
iShare	I11	11/09 - COUNSEL GENERAL	15 June 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground

		BRIEFING w/c 15.6.09		providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 3 point 6 re Airbus. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 6 point 15.
iShare	I12	12/09 - COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 29.6.09	29 June 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 7 point 6 re Airbus. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 12 point 15.
iShare	I13	14/09 - COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 10.8.09	10 August 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 28 point 6 re Airbus. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 32 point 15.
iShare	I14	16/09 COUNSEL GENERAL BRIEFING w/c 7.9.09	7 Septemb er 2009	These are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update to Counsel General. Docs confirm meetings with PM re airbus and AAM. ref to PM page 24 point 6 re Airbus. Ref to Anglesey Aluminium page 28 point

				15.
iShare	I17	2009-04-06 Current Issues 9 April 09 (2)	9 April 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I18	2009-05-05 Current Issues E&T 8 May 09	8 May 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I19	2009-05-18 Current Issues ET 22 May 09	22 May 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I20	2009-06-01 Current Issues ET 8 June 09	8 June 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc

				referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I21	2009-06-15 Current Issues ET 8 June 09	8 June 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I22	2009-06-29 Current Issues ET 3 July 09	3 July 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I23	2009-07-01 Current Issues ET 8 June 09	9 June 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I24	2009-08-10 Current Issues ET 13 August 09	13 August 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update

				on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I25	2009-09-07 ET 14 September 09	14 September 2009	I17 to I25 are all similar briefings and cover much the same ground providing status update on current issues. Point 5/6 re Airbus remains the same in each doc referencing continued dialogue with PM. Updated text included for AAM.
iShare	I170	Wales PMQ Briefing on Peoples Bank - 02 02 09	2 February 2009	The Secretary of State for Business, Enterprise and Regulatory Reform is reported to be promoting the idea of a "people's bank".